

Checklist: how to document difficult situations at work

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The company documents everything from your first day at work — emails, reviews, agreements. That's normal. And you have exactly the same right to do so.

Documenting is not informing on anyone and not preparing for war. It's calmly writing down **facts** so that six months from now you don't have to rely on memory — yours or anyone else's. It takes 5 minutes after a difficult conversation. Sometimes it's worth a great deal more.

1 · The rule: a note within 5 minutes of the conversation

Right after a difficult conversation, write down the facts — while you still remember them exactly. Not interpretations, not emotions. Facts.

DATE and TIME: 7 Jul 2026, approx. 2:30 pm
 WHO WAS PRESENT: me, [manager], [witnesses]
 WHERE / HOW: meeting room / online call / at the desk
 WHAT IT WAS ABOUT: (one or two sentences)

WHAT WAS SAID (specifically):
 - "[quote or close paraphrase]"

AGREEMENTS / EXPECTATIONS:
 - what, by when, by what criterion

WHAT I SAID / WHAT I ASKED ABOUT:
 - ...

TO DO ON MY SIDE:
 [] ...

Why it works: a week later, memory plays tricks on both sides. A dated note, written while it's fresh, **sorts out the facts and calms things down**.

2 · What to write down after every difficult situation

- ☐ Date and time — always, that's the basis
- ☐ Who was present (and who saw/heard it)
- ☐ Channel — conversation, meeting, email, messenger
- ☐ Specific words / expectations — quotes, not generalities
- ☐ Agreements — what, by when, by what criterion "done"
- ☐ What you said / what you asked about
- ☐ Your next steps after the conversation (and whether done)
- ☐ Written trail — a short summary by email, if the conversation was verbal

The overriding rule: **facts instead of judgements**. Instead of "my boss was unfair" → "I received feedback on X; no specific example was given".

3 · Where to keep your documentation

- ☐ A copy outside company equipment and accounts — access to your work laptop and email can be cut off overnight
- ☐ Private space — private email, private cloud, a notebook
- ☐ Don't copy confidential company data or other people's data — document your own situation and your own agreements
- ☐ Write as you go, not "someday" — an entry dated the same day is worth more

4 · 10 sentences: a calm reply to unfair feedback

Don't reply "in the heat of the moment". Wait, cool down, reply calmly and in writing. You can combine the sentences.

To buy time:

- 1 "Thank you. I want to respond properly — I'll come back to you by [date]."
- 2 "I'll summarise what we agreed by email, so we have it in writing."

To pin things down (generality → specific):

- 1 "Could we go through this on a specific example?"
- 2 "What would a sufficient result look like in practice?"
- 3 "How will we know the expectation has been met?"

To present your perspective:

- 1 "I understand the feedback. Let me add context that may matter: [facts]."
- 2 "I see this differently and I'd like to explain — I'm basing this on [specifics]."
- 3 "I want to improve. I'd like the assessment to be based on facts."

To leave a trail and close:

- 1 "For the record, here's a summary of what we agreed: [points]. Let me know if I've captured anything differently."
- 2 "If I understand correctly, by [date] I'm to [task] according to [criterion]. Can you confirm?"

5 · What NOT to do

- ☐ Don't reply to difficult feedback the same day, in the grip of emotion
- ☐ Don't write labels ("bullying", "spite") where facts are enough
- ☐ Don't record conversations without checking whether and when you're allowed to
- ☐ Don't take confidential company materials or other people's data
- ☐ Don't leave the only copy of your documentation on company equipment

Important: this is educational material, not legal advice. Every situation is different, and laws and internal regulations vary. If the matter is serious (suspected bullying, disciplinary action, a dispute over dismissal) — consult a lawyer or your labour inspectorate.

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